arrived that Hamida Banu, Gulbadan, and some of the other ladies from the capital had received Akbar's summons and were on their way. Daniyal was first sent out of the city to wait on the ladies, after which Murad was sent and then, finally, Salim. Akbar then went out of the city himself to welcome the ladies and a grand feast was held in honour of their arrival. Akbar was always very solicitous of the welfare of the older ladies, and was careful about the deference owed to them. The English traveller Thomas Coryat was astounded to note that, on one occasion, when Hamida Banu was returning to Agra from Lahore, Akbar and his amirs lifted the queen mother's palanquin on to their shoulders and carried her out of the city themselves.

After several pleasant months in Kabul, and though Akbar wished again 'that the active young men should behold the spectacle of the falling of snow, and should tread the ice, and that the natives of India might enjoy this', the Padshah was finally persuaded to head home. It was while they were camped at Begram, in November 1589, that news arrived of the death of an old and loyal courtier. Sensing that the end of his life was drawing near, a sick and feeble Raja Todar Mal had asked permission to retire to Haridwar, and he was on his way to the holy city when Akbar unexpectedly changed his mind, saying that 'no worship of God was equal to taking care of the weak. It was therefore better that he should look after the affairs of the oppressed.' Just as he had given up the practice of regular namaaz and ritual worship, Akbar believed that the worship of idols was not to be placed above duty towards the weak. Raja Todar Mal turned sadly back to Lahore, and died a few months later. Abu'l Fazl's somewhat uncharitable assessment of this grand old man, the backbone of Akbar's administrative reforms, was that 'he was unique of the Age for uprightness, straightforwardness, courage, knowledge of affairs and the administration of India. If he had not had bigotry, conventionalism, and spite, and had not stuck to his own opinions, he would have been one of the spiritually great.'

Raja Bhagwant Das went to attend to the funeral of his friend and returning to his house had a vomiting fit, and himself died five days later, in the cold Lahore winter far from his desert home. Badauni's report of the deaths of these two stalwarts of Akbar's court was positively gloating. They 'hastened to the abode of hell and torment,' was his assessment, 'and in the lowest pit became the food of serpents and scorpions, may God scorch them both!' For Badauni, all those Hindus at court who were honoured and rose